

Topic 5.2 - What is asked of you, and by whom

A real classroom situation

In one week, Mr Rafiq is told four things.

His head tells him the school's Class 10 results must improve. A parent tells him her son is being pushed too hard and is not sleeping. The district office sends a circular requiring a new monthly assessment return. A newspaper column, which several colleagues have read, says that government teachers are paid to do nothing.

Every one of these is a legitimate voice with a real interest in his work. No two of them are asking for the same thing, and one of them is asking for something incompatible with another. He has one week and one Class 10.

Explanation

The increased focus on teacher accountability

Accountability in teaching has grown steadily over the last three decades, in Pakistan and almost everywhere else. Unit 4 gave the mechanisms: standards, appraisal, licensing, inspection. This topic asks what their accumulation does to the person being held accountable.

The case for accountability is strong and this unit does not dispute it. A profession that cannot be held to account has no claim on public trust, as Unit 1 argued, and in a system where teacher absence and unprepared teaching are real problems, the demand for accountability is not an insult.

What is worth understanding is what accountability does when it arrives without the other half of the bargain. Isoré (2009), reviewing teacher evaluation across OECD countries, found the tension between accountability and development to be the central design problem of evaluation systems. Accountability mechanisms measure, compare and impose consequences. They do not, by themselves, supply anything that makes the measured work easier to do.

So a predictable pattern follows, and you should expect to see it:

- **What is measured becomes what is done.** If results are measured and understanding is not, teaching narrows toward results. Unit 3 made this point about effectiveness; it is the same mechanism.
- **Effort moves from the work to the record of the work.** The monthly return in Mr Rafiq's week is real work that produces no learning.
- **Accountability without autonomy produces compliance rather than improvement.** A teacher held responsible for an outcome they are given no power to affect will manage their exposure, which is rational.

Hargreaves (2000), tracing the historical phases of teacher professionalism, situates this: the demand for accountability is part of a long movement in how societies relate to teaching, not a recent invention or a local grievance.

The practical conclusion for a trainee is narrow and useful. When you meet an accountability demand, ask what it measures and what it supplies. If it measures and supplies nothing, it will change your behaviour without improving your teaching, and knowing that lets you protect the teaching.

High expectations from many stakeholders at once

The figure above maps the parties and, crucially, distinguishes **what each wants** from **what each measures**. Those two are different for almost every party, and the gap is where most of a teacher's difficulty lives.

- **Pupils** want to be treated fairly and to understand. What they can judge is mostly fairness and clarity, not whether the curriculum was covered.
- **Parents** want their child to succeed and be safe. Many measure by marks, because marks are the only signal the system gives them.

- **The head** wants a school that runs and results that hold up. Measures attendance, compliance, and examination outcomes.
- **The district** wants returns filed and standards met. Measures paperwork, because paperwork is what travels up a system.
- **The examination system** wants coverage of the syllabus. Measures one paper.
- **The public** wants a profession worth funding. Measures by anecdote and by newspaper column.

Three things follow. **The demands genuinely conflict**: the parent asking Mr Rafiq to ease off and the head asking for better results cannot both be satisfied by the same action. **No party sees the whole job**, so each judges from a partial view that feels complete from where they stand. And **the teacher is the only person positioned to see all of it**, which is a responsibility and also the reason the work feels isolating.

What a professional does with this is not satisfy everyone, which is impossible, but decide explicitly whose claim takes priority when they conflict, and be able to say why. Unit 2's dilemma material is the tool: name the competing goods, accept that something will be lost, and choose where the loss falls. In Mr Rafiq's case the pupil's welfare and the pupil's results are both his to weigh, and the newspaper column is not a claim on him at all.

Socio-economic status and public recognition

Occupational status is the standing a society accords a line of work: what it pays, who it attracts, how it is spoken about, and how much independence its members are granted.

Teaching's status is uneven rather than simply low, and the figure above is built to show that. Against medicine or law, teaching in Pakistan typically has lower pay, a less selective entry route and less day-to-day autonomy. Against many other occupations it has greater security, substantial social respect in some communities, and a moral standing that survives even hostile newspaper columns.

The relationship between status and recognition runs in both directions, and this is the part worth thinking about carefully.

Status shapes who enters. Where teaching is a fallback rather than a first choice, the profession recruits accordingly, and Unit 3's discussion of attitude toward the profession becomes a live problem rather than an abstraction.

Practice shapes recognition. A public forms its view of teachers from the teachers it meets: its own, its children's, the one at the gate who did or did not have time to talk. The newspaper column that angered Mr Rafiq's colleagues was written by someone with their own school memories.

And recognition is not the same as status. A teacher can be genuinely respected in their community while the occupation remains poorly paid and weakly trusted nationally. Conflating the two produces the misconception this section exists to correct: *a teacher's status is fixed by society and nothing a teacher does affects it*. The occupation's structural position is not something one teacher can shift. The recognition extended to teachers in one community, by the people who deal with them, is affected by what those teachers do every day, and Unit 2's account of the profession's collective standing is the same argument.

That is not a call to be satisfied with poor pay and to seek respect instead. Structural conditions require structural remedies, and Topic 5.4 is explicit that some things are not within a teacher's control. It is a statement about which part of the problem is in your hands.

Activity: Four demands, one week

Work in groups of four. Take Mr Rafiq's week from the top of this topic and assign one demand to each member: the head's, the parent's, the district's, the newspaper's.

Argue your assigned party's case as strongly as you can, in turn, including what that party would say about the others' demands.

Then decide as a group: which demands are genuine claims on Mr Rafiq, which are not claims on him at all, and in what order should the genuine ones be honoured? You must reach a ranking and be able to state the criterion you used.

Allow 30 minutes. The most useful disagreement is usually about the newspaper column.

Check your understanding

1. Explain what accountability mechanisms measure and what they do not supply. (*Understand*)
2. Give two predictable effects of accountability arriving without autonomy. (*Remember*)
3. For any three stakeholders, state what that party wants and what it actually measures. (*Apply*)
4. Explain why no single party is in a position to judge a teacher's whole job, and what follows from that. (*Analyze*)
5. Distinguish occupational status from public recognition, and explain why conflating them leads teachers to conclude that nothing they do matters. (*Analyze*)

Summary

Accountability in teaching has grown steadily and the case for it is sound. What it does not do by itself is supply anything that makes the measured work easier. Where it arrives without autonomy or resources, three things follow predictably: what is measured becomes what is done, effort shifts from the work to the record of the work, and teachers manage their exposure rather than improving their practice.

Many parties make demands on a teacher, and for almost all of them what they want and what they measure are different things. The demands genuinely conflict, no party sees the whole job, and the teacher is the only person who does. The professional response is not to satisfy everyone but to decide whose claim takes priority and be able to justify it.

Teaching's status is uneven rather than simply low. Status shapes who enters the profession; practice shapes the recognition a community extends to it. The two are not the same, and conflating them produces the belief that nothing a

teacher does affects how teaching is regarded, which is false of recognition even where it is true of structural status.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can state the case for accountability and what it fails to supply.
- ☐ I can predict what accountability without autonomy does to behaviour.
- ☐ I can distinguish what each stakeholder wants from what each measures.
- ☐ I can rank conflicting demands and state the criterion I used.
- ☐ I can distinguish status from recognition and say which part is affected by my own practice.

Try this at your practicum school

Ask three people connected to your practicum school what they think makes a good teacher: a pupil, a parent if you can, and a teacher or the head.

Write half a page comparing the three answers against what each of them is actually in a position to observe. The usual finding is that each answer is accurate about the part they see and incomplete about the rest, which is the topic's central point arriving as evidence rather than assertion.

Summative task

Write 450 to 500 words.

Mr Rafiq has four demands and one week. Decide what he should do, and justify the order.

Name each demand, say what the party wants and what it measures, identify which are genuine claims on him and which are not, and give a ranking with the criterion it rests on. Then address the objection that ignoring the head's demand is not realistic for someone whose confirmation and transfer depend on that head's report.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	What a strong response does
Analysis of demands (Apply)	Separates what each party wants from what it measures, for every demand
Identification of non-claims	Argues which demands are not claims on him at all, rather than ranking all four
Justified ranking (Evaluate)	States the criterion the ranking rests on and defends choosing it, rather than asserting an order
Realism about consequence (Analyze)	Engages with the career cost of deprioritising the head, rather than recommending a course that ignores it

Further reading

- Isoré, M. (2009). *Teacher evaluation: Current practices in OECD countries and a literature review* (OECD Education Working Papers No. 23). OECD Publishing. <https://files.eric.ed.gov/fulltext/ED530786.pdf>
- Hargreaves, A. (2000). Four ages of professionalism and professional learning. *Teachers and Teaching*, 6(2), 151-182.
<https://doi.org/10.1080/713698714>

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